INDIAN SCHOOL AL WADI AL KABIR

Parent Connect Bulletin

GRADE IX & XII

Monthly Focus

# Supporting Career Awareness & Decision Making

## Overview

Career awareness is a journey of discovery, not a one-time decision. The most confident and successful students are those who gradually build self-awareness, explore opportunities, and make informed choices over time—not those who wait until their final year to decide.

## 1. Self Awareness

Before "what job," students need clarity on:

- **Interests** — what subjects, activities, or problems genuinely pull their attention (not just what they're good at)
- **Strengths and natural abilities** — academic and non-academic (leadership, creativity, mechanical aptitude, empathy, etc.)
- **Values** — what they want from work: income, stability, flexibility, impact, status, creativity, independence
- **Work style preferences** — indoors/outdoors, team/solo, structured/flexible, people-facing/behind-the-scenes

## 2. World-of-Work Awareness

Students (and parents) often have narrow mental map of careers. Useful awareness includes:

- **Breadth of options** — most people can only name jobs they've personally seen; exposure to a wider range (trades, healthcare support roles, tech-adjacent non-coding jobs, entrepreneurship, government, etc.) matters
- **Pathways aren't just "4-year degree or bust"** — apprenticeships, community college transfer routes, certifications, military, and direct-entry trades are legitimate and sometimes financially smarter paths
- **How the job market is shifting** — automation/AI is changing which skills are durable (adaptability, communication, complex problem-solving) versus which routine tasks are being automated
- **Real cost/return information** — what different paths cost and realistic salary ranges, so decisions aren't made on assumptions

## 3. Decision Making Skills

Teach the *process*:

- **Explore before committing** — job shadowing, informational interviews, internships, part-time jobs, volunteering all give low-stakes data
- **Decision-making frameworks** — simple tools like weighing pros/cons against personal values, or "would this door stay open" thinking (avoiding choices that foreclose too many future options too early)
- **Tolerating uncertainty** — normalize not having it figured out at 17; the goal is a good next step, not a lifetime plan

## 4. What can Parents do?

Understand and guide them

- **Ask open questions instead of prescribing paths** — "what did you enjoy about that?" rather than "you should be a doctor"
- **Share their own career story honestly** — including detours, mistakes, and how their path actually unfolded (rarely linear)
- **Expose**, **don't push** — bring kids along to workplaces, introduce them to people in different fields, encourage part-time work
- **Watch for projecting their own unmet goals or fears** onto the student
- **Support exploration financially/logistically** where possible (a summer job, a community college class, a certification course) rather than only funding one "approved" path

**Important Timeline:**

- **9th–10th grade**: broad exploration, self-assessment, exposure to many fields, no pressure to decide
- **11th grade**: narrowing based on interests, job shadowing/internships, research on pathways and costs
- **12th grade**: concrete next-step planning (specific programs, applications, financial aid), while keeping the mindset that this is a next step, not a final answer